In reality, Afghanistan and India probably had an equal need for the friendship of each other – a fact that the Home government failed to recognise but of which the Indian government was well aware. In the opinion of Delhi, Britain was faced with two choices (other than another Afghan war): to accept working alongside the Bolsheviks within Afghanistan, or to remain entirely detached from that country. As Chelmsford put it: 'The exclusive domination of Afghanistan, which we should doubtless much prefer, has been rendered impossible by development of events unless we go to war.'[82] It was the first course that the Indian government would much prefer, and as such would push for in 1921. As for Afghan duplicity, Chelmsford explained in March 1921 that 'as much as we may object to Amir's trying to get the utmost out of both sides without committing himself against either, it is not in our power to object effectively'.[83] This was the reality of the situation in Delhi's eyes and, as such, in its opinion, Britain could not afford to be sensitive or overly demanding when it came to its negotiations with Afghanistan.

Unfortunately for the Government of India, the Home government did not agree. Indeed, there were some in London who could still not accept that it was not within Britain's power to hold sway over Afghanistan's foreign relations. In February 1921, in response to a draft treaty Chelmsford proposed to offer the emir, Montagu suggested that the viceroy:

should consider the possibility of adding some provision such as that it will be open to [the] Government of India to offer [the] Afghan Government, and for the Afghan Government to ask of the Government of India, advice in a friendly way in regard to foreign relations of Afghanistan.[84]

This, despite the persistent argument from the Indian government that it had absolutely no chance of gaining any such concession from Afghanistan. In spite of the viceroy's best efforts, London still either did not understand or refused to accept the changes that had overcome that nation since the Third Anglo-Afghan War. In all of their negotiations, Amanullah and his government were fiercely protective of their new-found independence in